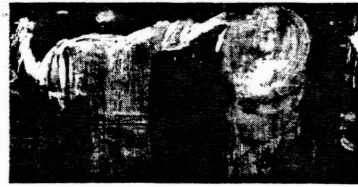


arts

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Maurice Sievan, *Zexus*, 1962. Oil on canvas, 55 x 104". Courtesy Vanderwoude Tananbaum Gallery.

MAURICE SIEVAN

Oil paintings done by Maurice Sievan from 1958 through the 1960s reflect a concern for the human dilemma of ideals in conflict with the limits and constraints of human capacity and judgment in society. Like Kierkegaard, Sievan investigates despair in his paintings. He uses thin paint, vigorously splashed on in loose, drippy, broad strokes, and a dark or muted palette to suggest helpless human presences who are universalized by their lack of identifiable features. Rather, these figures are like primal screams, visual voices that express the tortures of surviving alone, isolated in a treacherous world.

Study for Compalik (1962) is an intimate drawing, a kind of non-portrait portrait. There seems to be a frontal standing female in a red-orange dress facing out at the viewer. Another face is suggested behind her on the upper left side of the canvas. The figures occupy a little more than half the left portion of the drawing while a thin horizontal form seems to point, joining their heads and the right edge of the canvas. *Compalik* is a large vertical painting which resolves the problems presented in the drawing. The palette is rich yet simple and restricted. A dark rich, dense, muted turquoise, which fades out and seems darker toward the edges, surrounds a glowing female figure in a red dress. The glow results from the scraping away of some areas of the red paint, leaving the white of the canvas shining through the paint.

Boobershek is a startling, quite remarkable painting which has something of the presence of an opera singer. It suggests a figure standing with arms folded behind its back with two large forms, almost half circles facing and opposing each other on two sides of the figure's head and chest, reminiscent of a large

robe or fur-coat collar. The palette is black at bottom. This surrounds a blue-gray figure which gets lighter at the chest area and lightest around the head which appears cut off at the top. A muted red surrounds the upper part of the figure and a brighter red circle which becomes black in the center suggests a wide open mouth or a vacant head. The paint handling becomes substance versus no substance. Perhaps the large imposing scale and demeanor of the figure is contradicted by this suggested open void.

Vurkalus is smaller in scale than most of the other paintings and is the most specific and defined portrait in the exhibition. The off colors here are muted, smeared grayed red for the figure with a primitive smearing of black suggesting features of an Oceanic or African mask. A yellow mixed with gray surrounds the figure from the shoulders up, with a stroke of light green punctuating the top of the head on the left side of the canvas while a red area glows on the opposite side of the head. Looming dabs of black punctuate the background. They seem to be the most concrete and tangible portions of the painting. The figure seems huge, blown up and pendulous, weighted down and vulnerable. Two swollen, short, arm-like forms press against each other, seemingly unable to move and unable to protect the obviously vulnerable, agonized figure which stares out helplessly at the viewer. This sickly sanguine figure personifies the struggle for existence; the entire body of work presented is a moving testimony to that struggle. (Vanderwoude-Tananbaum, March 1-April 2)

By ELLEN LEE KLEIN